



# Party in a Geriatric **WARD**

The doddering comrades refuse to allow a generational shift in leadership, making it all the more vulnerable to the youthful Opposition

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

**T**he picture was worth more than a thousand words: a small sea of white tops as the leadership of the CPI(M) paid homage to their departed leader Jyoti Basu. The old guard had indeed turned old: Prakash Karat, 61, Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, 66, Biman Bose, 70, and Manik Sarkar, 61, stood with clenched fists while Sitaram Yechury, more salt, less pepper, was in relatively splendid isolation. On that sad day for communists, the 57-year-old Yechury was the one exception.